

To Billy Blaine and Breanne

Did you know that your great, great, great grand-father was killed by a bull? He was my grand-father, my mothers father.

His name was Mathias Oswald. His parents came from Hanover Germany and they settled in Pennsylvania for awhile and with relatives and friends came to Kansas and helped to establish the town of Hanover Kansas.

Mathias was married twice and had a large family of children and several died in infancy but seven grew up and are listed in the Schmidt family Tree

Mat, as he was known, homesteaded a farm on the



Little Blue river, four miles south of Hanover Kansas. Half of the farm, next to the river had lots of trees but was farmed as the trees were cleared away. The other half of the farm was on hilly ground and called pasture land.

He was a farmer and also a cattle buyer and feeder. Cattle were usually grass-fed a couple of years and then put in Feed Lots and stuffed with corn to make them fat and heavy to be sold to the slaughter houses.

It was told that at some time in his life he had driven a freight wagon from Omaha Nebraska to Abeline Kansas. There were no established



roads then, only trails and Indians and Buffalos still roamed the prairies. There were no bridges so they had to find ways to cross the streams and rivers and of course they were out in all kinds of weather for weeks at a time. Several wagons together made up a wagon train.

My mother told me that Indians would come to their home and were allowed to come into the house and that they would try to trade anything they had, which wasnt much, for anything they saw even food on the table. They were friendly Indians and they tried to treat them nice but they were a little afraid of them as there were so many



bad stories told about them.

Another story was that a roving band of Indians found a dead horse that had been thrown in a ditch and they built a fire and cooked and ate it and partied till late in the night.

The Oswald family was very influential and popular and are mentioned in the Washington County Centennial on the early history of the county.

The original Oswald home was made from white stone from the hillside and was later remodeled and looks much the same as I remember it seventy or more years ago.

As the buffalo were killed off cattle were introduced and



raised. Cows could be turned loose on open range and they would increase and have calves and they would also reproduce with practically no care or attention. Cattle were branded with a hot iron with an insigne of the owner and were rounded up once a year and new calves branded and meby some of the stock sent to market. Cattle raising is still a big industry in the United States.

The Oswald homestead had a large feed lot and they "fed Out", cattle year after year. As you know, (I hope) a bull is necessary to a herd of cattle and some of these critters were very cranky and would try to



protect their cows from any intrusion. It is said that anything red would make them mad.

I can recall crossing many pastures with cattle in them but was always alert for any bulls.

On one particular morning my grand-father had occasion to go in the feed lot alone and they heard him call for help and they came and chased the bull away but he was so badly hurt that he died soon afterwards.

They said it was the largest funeral ever in Washington County and the parade of buggies and wagons and some on foot and horse-back was over four miles long.



He was considered a rich man in those days and he owned several sections of land in western Kansas.

His estate was estimated at eighty thousand dollars but with many children the shares were small. My mother took a half-section of western land for her share.

He is, in my belief, the most out-standing man in our family history

Kenneth Oswald Schmidt